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How to Diagnose Fit

Learn the three-step method for reading any garment's fit problems.

Every fit issue shows itself in one of three ways: pulling, bunching, or gaping. Once you can read the signs, the fix becomes obvious.

The three-step method

- 1 Put on the garment and stand naturally** — feet shoulder-width apart, arms at your sides, looking straight ahead.
- 2 Check in a full-length mirror** — look at the front, turn to see each side, then use a second mirror for the back.
- 3 Move: raise your arms, sit, bend** — fit problems that hide while standing appear when you move.

Do this

Wear the undergarments and shoes you plan to wear with the finished garment — they change how it fits and where the hemline falls.

What to look for

SIGN	WHAT IT MEANS	LIKELY FIX
Horizontal pulling lines	Too tight in that area	Let out or reshape seams
Vertical pulling lines	Too short or too narrow at the shoulder	Lengthen or widen the shoulder
Bunching / excess fabric	Too loose in that area	Take in seams or add darts
Gaping (neckline, armhole)	Opening is too large for your frame	Reduce the opening or add a dart
Riding up	Garment is pulled by a tight area above	Release the tight area, adjust the balance

Shoulders & Upper Body

Check the shoulder seam position and upper back fit.

Shoulder fit checklist

- ☐ Shoulder seam sits exactly at the edge of the shoulder bone
- ☐ No wrinkles radiating from the shoulder point
- ☐ Fabric lies flat across the upper back with no pulling
- ☐ No excess fabric bunching below the back of the collar
- ☐ You can raise both arms without the garment pulling up at the waist

Common problems and fixes

PROBLEM	WHAT YOU SEE	FIX	MANUAL GUIDE
Shoulder seam falls off the shoulder	Seam sits on the upper arm	Take in at the shoulder seam	Chapter 5
Shoulder seam too high	Seam sits on top of the shoulder, fabric pulls	Let out the shoulder or reshape armhole	Chapter 5
Back pulls tight	Horizontal creases across upper back	Let out the center back seam	Chapter 3
Back bunches	Vertical folds of excess fabric	Take in with back darts	Chapter 4

Bust & Chest

Diagnose fit across the bust line and mid-torso.

Bust fit checklist

- ☐ Buttons do not pull or gap across the bust
- ☐ Fabric lies flat between the bust and the armhole
- ☐ No diagonal wrinkles from the bust to the side seam
- ☐ The garment does not ride up in the front
- ☐ The neckline sits where it should — not pulling open or pressing against the throat

PROBLEM	WHAT YOU SEE	FIX	MANUAL GUIDE
Buttons gap	Gaps between buttons across the bust	Add bust darts or let out side seams	Chapter 4, Guide 10
Too tight, no buttons	Horizontal pulling at bust level	Let out side seams	Chapter 3, Guide 8
Too loose	Excess fabric droops below the bust	Add or deepen bust darts	Chapter 4, Guide 10
Neckline gaps	Neckline stands away from the chest	Reduce the neckline opening	Chapter 7, Guide 19

Common mistake

Taking in the side seams to fix a bust gap — this makes the waist too tight. Add darts at the bust level instead.

Waist & Hips

Check the waistband, waist shaping and hip fit.

Waist & hip checklist

- ☐ Waistband sits at your natural waist without rolling or folding
- ☐ No gap between the waistband and your body at the back
- ☐ Fabric does not pull across the hips when standing or sitting
- ☐ Side seams hang straight down, not angled forward or backward
- ☐ You can sit comfortably without the waistband digging in

PROBLEM	WHAT YOU SEE	FIX	MANUAL GUIDE
Waistband gaps at back	Visible gap when standing	Take in the center back seam	Chapter 3, Guide 7
Waistband too tight	Fabric pulls, uncomfortable sitting	Let out side seams or center back	Chapter 3, Guide 8
Hip area pulls	Horizontal creases at hip level	Let out at the hip, keep waist as-is	Chapter 3, Guide 9
Excess at waist	Fabric bunches at the waist	Take in side seams or add waist darts	Chapter 3, Guide 9

Sleeves & Arms

Check sleeve width, length and armhole fit.

Sleeve fit checklist

- ☐ Sleeve cap sits smoothly with no puckering at the seam
- ☐ Armhole does not dig in or gap when arms are at your sides
- ☐ Sleeve hangs straight — the side seam runs down the outer arm
- ☐ You can bend your elbow fully without the sleeve pulling tight
- ☐ Sleeve length hits the right point (wrist bone for shirts, 1 cm above for jackets)

PROBLEM	WHAT YOU SEE	FIX	MANUAL GUIDE
Armhole too big	Fabric gaps below the arm	Raise and narrow the armhole	Chapter 5, Guide 14
Armhole too tight	Fabric pulls when you move	Lower the armhole carefully	Chapter 5, Guide 14
Sleeves too wide	Excess fabric billows around the arm	Take in along the underarm seam	Chapter 5, Guide 13
Sleeves too long	Fabric pools at the wrist	Shorten from the bottom	Chapter 2, Guide 6

Length & Hemline

Check the hemline from every angle — gravity treats fabric differently on the bias.

Hemline checklist

- ☐ Hem is parallel to the floor all the way around
- ☐ Front and back lengths are equal (measure from the floor, not the waist)
- ☐ Hem does not dip on the bias grain (common on A-line and circle skirts)
- ☐ Trouser hem breaks at the shoe correctly (one soft fold for dress trousers)
- ☐ Dress or skirt length flatters and does not pull up when sitting

PROBLEM	WHAT YOU SEE	FIX	MANUAL GUIDE
Hem uneven	Higher on one side, dips on another	Re-mark from the floor and re-hem	Chapter 2, Guide 3–5
Too long	Trousers drag, dress pools	Shorten — mark while wearing shoes	Chapter 2, Guide 3–5
Too short	Not enough length after washing	Let down existing hem if allowance permits	Chapter 2

Do this

Always mark the new hemline while wearing the shoes and undergarments you will wear with the finished garment.

Trousers & Skirts

Specific fit checks for bottoms — crotch, rise and thigh.

Trouser fit checklist

- ☐ Crotch seam sits comfortably — not too high (pulls) or too low (droops)
- ☐ Front crease (if present) hangs straight from the front pleat to the shoe
- ☐ No "smile lines" — curved wrinkles below the front crotch
- ☐ Back rise covers without gaping when you bend or sit
- ☐ Thigh area has enough room to walk and sit without pulling
- ☐ Knee area does not bag after wearing

PROBLEM	WHAT YOU SEE	FIX	MANUAL GUIDE
Crotch too tight	Fabric pulls upward, uncomfortable	Lower the crotch curve or let out inseam	Chapter 9
Crotch too low	Fabric droops between legs	Take in the crotch seam	Chapter 9
Thighs pull	Horizontal lines across thighs	Let out the inseam at the thigh	Chapter 3
Skirt twists	Side seam migrates to front or back	Re-balance the front and back pieces	Chapter 3

Quick Decision Flowchart

Start here when you are not sure what is wrong — answer each question to find the right fix.

Work from the top of the garment downward. Fix the highest problem first — a shoulder fix often solves issues that appear at the waist.

Top-down diagnosis

- 1 Shoulders correct?** — If not, fix the shoulder seam position first (Section 2).
- 2 Bust / chest smooth?** — If pulling or gaping, add darts or adjust side seams (Section 3).
- 3 Waist comfortable?** — If too tight or too loose, adjust the waistband or side seams (Section 4).
- 4 Sleeves right?** — If too long, too wide or restricted, fix the sleeve (Section 5).
- 5 Hemline level?** — If uneven, re-mark and re-hem (Section 6).
- 6 Try on again** — After each fix, re-check from the top. One change can solve (or create) others.

Common mistake

Fixing the hem before fixing the shoulders or waist — upper body changes shift the hemline, so you end up hemming twice.

When to alter

- Fit issues are in one or two areas
- Seam allowance provides enough room
- Fabric is in good condition
- The garment is worth the time

When not to alter

- Fit issues are everywhere
- The garment is more than two sizes off
- Fabric is worn thin or damaged
- The alteration cost would exceed replacement

Next Step

Put on a garment that has always bothered you. Work through this checklist from Section 1 to Section 7, write down every issue you find, then open **The Complete Clothing Alterations Manual** to the guide that matches each one. Start with the highest problem and work down.